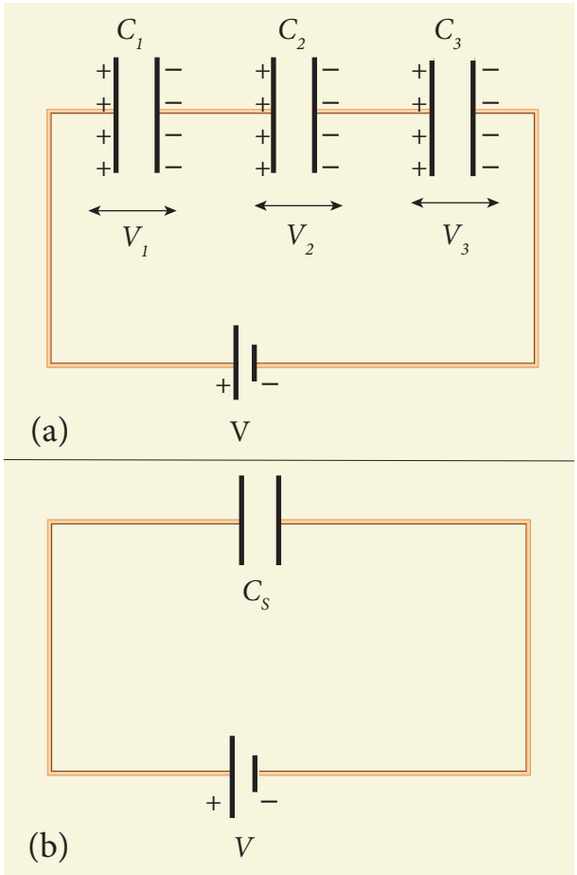


Figure 1.58 (a) Capacitors connected in series (b) Equivalent capacitors C_S

$-Q$ are transferred from negative terminal to the right plate of C_3 which pushes the electrons of same amount $-Q$ from left plate of C_3 to the right plate of C_2 due to electrostatic induction. Similarly, the left plate of C_2 pushes the charges of $-Q$ to the right plate of C_1 which induces the positive charge $+Q$ on the left plate of C_1. At the same time, electrons of charge $-Q$ are transferred from left plate of C_1 to positive terminal of the battery.

By these processes, each capacitor stores the same amount of charge Q. The capacitances of the capacitors are in general different, so that the voltage across each capacitor is also different and are denoted as V_1, V_2 and V_3 respectively.

The sum of the voltages across the capacitor must be equal to the voltage of the battery.

$$V = V_1 + V_2 + V_3 \qquad (1.103)$$

Since, $Q = CV$, we have $V = \frac{Q}{C_1} + \frac{Q}{C_2} + \frac{Q}{C_3}$

$$= Q\left(\frac{1}{C_1} + \frac{1}{C_2} + \frac{1}{C_3}\right) \qquad (1.104)$$

If three capacitors in series are considered to form an equivalent single capacitor C_s shown in Figure 1.58(b), then we have $V = \frac{Q}{C_S}$. Substituting this expression into equation (1.104), we get

$$\frac{Q}{C_S} = Q\left(\frac{1}{C_1} + \frac{1}{C_2} + \frac{1}{C_3}\right)$$

$$\frac{1}{C_S} = \frac{1}{C_1} + \frac{1}{C_2} + \frac{1}{C_3} \qquad (1.105)$$

Thus, the inverse of the equivalent capacitance C_S of three capacitors connected in series is equal to the sum of the inverses of each capacitance. This equivalent capacitance C_S is always less than the smallest individual capacitance in the series.

(ii) Capacitance in parallel

Consider three capacitors of capacitance C_1, C_2 and C_3 connected in parallel with a battery of voltage V as shown in Figure 1.59 (a).

Since corresponding sides of the capacitors are connected to the same positive and negative terminals of the battery, the voltage across each capacitor is equal to the battery's voltage. Since capacitances of the capacitors are different,

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